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~~TOP SECRET~~

May 3, 1951



MEMORANDUM FOR THE PRESIDENT:

The following notes contain a summary of the discussion at the 90th Meeting of the National Security Council, at which you presided.

1. THE SITUATION IN THE FAR EAST

At the conclusion of General Bradley's briefing, SECRETARY MARSHALL observed that there were at least some important advantages to be derived from the unhappy conflict in which we are engaged in Korea. There had been marked improvement in the operating liaison among the services, and the system of rotation of forces would contribute enormously to the efficient training of American troops in this country. Above all, the Korean conflict was providing a school of arms. Out of it we are getting a practical and hardened soldiery. This was comparable to the experience of the British fleet during the Napoleonic wars. At sea during that entire conflict, the British fleet ended by establishing its mastery of the seas.

THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:

Noted an oral briefing by the Chairman, Joint Chiefs of Staff, on the military situation in Korea.

2. UNITED STATES OBJECTIVES, POLICIES AND COURSES OF ACTION IN ASIA (NSC 48/3, corrected by Memo for All Holders of NSC 48/3, dated April 27, 1951; Annex to NSC 48/3; Memo for NSC from Executive Secretary, same subject, dated May 1, 1951)

THE PRESIDENT introduced NSC 48/3 and, after remarking on the several versions of the paper which he had seen in draft, invited Secretary Acheson "to discourse on the subject".

SECRETARY ACHESON commenced by remarking that NSC 48/3 was a good paper, which would prove to be very helpful. He said he had a few minor changes to suggest, but that he would not bother the Council with them at this time but would instead give them to Mr. Lay for reference to the Senior NSC Staff.

THE PRESIDENT also remarked that he had some suggestions of a minor character.

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SECRETARY ACHESON then directed the Council's attention to the Joint Chiefs of Staff views and recommendations. He expressed general agreement on the need to improve paragraph 6 of NSC 48/3, which he thought could be readily done by the Senior Staff.

THE PRESIDENT expressed some concern about the phrase "oriented toward", in paragraphs 5-a and 6-c. The President suggested that what was really meant was better supplied by the phrase "friendly to". We don't want, he added, to force people into agreeable attitudes toward us; what we did desire was to assure friendly relationships.

The President then turned to paragraph 8-b and inquired whether it was actually necessary to use the phrase "by both overt and covert means", and also whether it was essential to state as a course of action that we wished "to oppose the present Peiping regime". In subparagraph d of the same paragraph, the President expressed doubt as to the desirability of using the phrase "create fissions", since this might suggest in some minds an intention to use atomic weapons.

GENERAL SMITH explained the reason for the reference to covert means, and expressed the hope that, if the phrase were deleted, the National Security Council would provide him instead with a one-paragraph directive so that he would have authority to conduct the operations for which he was responsible. General Smith suggested that the NSC Staff be asked to draft such a directive for him.

NATIONAL ARCHIVES AND RECORDS SERVICE

SECRETARY ACHESON then referred to the changes recommended by the Joint Chiefs of Staff in paragraph 9-b-(2). He thought that the JCS language was at least an improvement over the existing statement, but said that the phraseology should be worked out in the Senior Staff.

Secretary Acheson then went on to comment on the JCS suggestions with respect to paragraphs 11-a and 11-c. He thought that both the JCS suggestions should be carefully scrutinized. He said it was a question of real doubt as to whether the Chinese forces on Formosa could ever be made strong enough to defend that island without the assistance of the Seventh Fleet. With respect to the JCS suggestion in paragraph 11-c, Secretary Acheson said that the JCS phraseology gave the suggestion of an unlimited increase in the aid which the United States might have to provide for Formosa. Furthermore, Secretary Acheson did not like the idea, which might be read into the paragraph on Formosa, that that island was never to become a part of any China and that we should hold Formosa for an indefinite period or forever. What we really wanted, said Secretary Acheson, was to keep Formosa out of the hands of an unfriendly China, not out of the hands of a friendly China. Going on, Secretary Acheson observed that one of the major reasons why we might find it extremely difficult to create fission or to induce mass defections among the peoples and military leaders of Communist China, was because of our very close connection

with the Chiang Kai-shek regime. Let us not then, said Secretary Acheson, adopt a policy which might seem to commit us to an unlimited increase of Chiang Kai-shek's potential. On the contrary, our real purpose should be to build up Formosa defensively. Otherwise we shall find ourselves pouring in unlimited amounts of aid and of materiel. Secretary Acheson suggested that the Senior Staff deal with the issue that he had raised, and expressed the view that the Joint Chiefs of Staff themselves were probably desirous of putting some kind of limitation on the mission of the Seventh Fleet. He did not believe, however, that the present phraseology really constituted a limitation on the mission of the Fleet, and asked General Bradley's views.

GENERAL BRADLEY confirmed that it was the intention of the Joint Chiefs of Staff to place a limit on the mission of the Fleet.

In response to a query from Secretary Marshall, SECRETARY ACHESON again explained his view that the status of Formosa would change if out of the present situation we got a friendly China or an opposition force in China which might make use of the Nationalist forces on Formosa. Secretary Acheson thought words could be found to express the JCS intention more accurately, and GENERAL BRADLEY stated that he thought the intentions of the Joint Chiefs would be made clear if a period were placed at the end of "Formosa" in paragraph 11-c and the rest of the sentence deleted.

Secretary Acheson said that in any case he would not want language which would commit us to all-out and limitless assistance to Chiang Kai-shek.

MR. LAY pointed out the connection between the use of the forces on Formosa in paragraph 11-c to the courses of action which were referred to in sub-paragraph f on page 7. In short, said Mr. Lay, the assistance and support which it is proposed to give to Formosa would depend on the plans for action in sub-paragraph f on page 7.



THE PRESIDENT expressed the belief that the differences which were being discussed were primarily differences with respect to wording rather than to differences as to policy.

MR. SYMINGTON inquired, in the light of Secretary Acheson's statements, whether there was really any practical chance of a falling-out among the Communist military leaders which would result in fissions and the emergence of a new leadership in Communist China. Was this a real or merely a theoretical possibility?

In reply to Mr. Symington, GENERAL SMITH admitted that it was very difficult to give a satisfactory answer. It is always possible, said General Smith, to start a fire, but the fire can't be kept going unless fuel is provided. What was needed in China was the provision of

a stable rallying point which might either be the present Nationalist forces or some other dissident group. You could, he added, probably cause the defection of a Communist Chinese general or two at some cost, but such defections would amount to very little unless a political rallying point was provided. This was a problem to which the Departments of State and Defense would presently have to give serious consideration.

With respect to the JCS views and recommendations on NSC 48/3, General Smith stated that the board of the National Estimates Staff of CIA had reviewed the appropriate sections. They had found some of the assumptions in these sections debatable. General Smith said that if the Council so desired, he would present the review by the National Estimates Board to the Senior Staff for use in the revision of the paper.

SECRETARY MARSHALL, alluding to the Joint Chiefs of Staff views and recommendations, stated that with respect to paragraph 6-e on page 4 he had himself a rough draft of a possible substitute. He observed that much of this paragraph was within the realm of political policy, which was not his province; but he nevertheless would be glad to pass out copies of his rough memorandum in the hope that it might be of some use even though the matter was primarily one for the Department of State.

In response to a query from the President as to whether there were any further points to be raised, MR. LAY asked about the time limit which the Council desired to place on the revision of NSC 48/3 which would be undertaken by the Senior NSC Staff.

THE PRESIDENT said that the revision should be completed as promptly as possible and indeed, if possible, in time for consideration at next week's Council meeting.

THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:



a. Discussed the draft statement of policy on the subject contained in NSC 48/3 and the views and recommendations of the Joint Chiefs of Staff with respect thereto contained in the reference memorandum of May 1, 1951.

b. Referred NSC 48/3 and the Annex to NSC 48/3 to the NSC Staff for revision in the light of the discussion at the meeting, the revision to be prepared for consideration at the next regular Council meeting on May 9, 1951.

3. NSC 26/5

(NSC 26/5; Progress Report, dated April 3, 1951, by the Under Secretary of State on NSC 26/2 and NSC 26/4; Memo for NSC from Executive Secretary, same subject, dated May 1, 1951.)

MR. LAY explained the gist of the paper.

THE NATIONAL SECURITY COUNCIL:

a. Adopted the statement of policy contained in NSC 26/5.

b. Noted the reference Progress Report by the Under Secretary of State on NSC 26/2 and NSC 26/4.

NOTE: The statement of policy contained in NSC 26/5 subsequently submitted to the President for consideration.

4. NSC STATUS OF PROJECTS

Noted the status of NSC projects as of April 30, 1951.

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THE PRESIDENT referred to the forthcoming departure of Mr. Symington from membership in the National Security Council, and to the fact that his temporary successor would be Mr. Jack Gorrie, who had been present at the meeting.